

> ***"Goa has always been India's most loved destination. Our task now is to make it India's most responsibly managed one - because the only tourism that lasts is tourism that the land can sustain and the people can be proud of."***

Rohan Khaunte, *Minister for Tourism, Information Technology, Electronics & Communications and Printing & Stationery, Government of Goa.*

its emerging spiritual tourism identity?

Goa does not have to choose between spirituality and entertainment. It has to govern both responsibly. Goa's identity has always been layered. A visitor may attend a temple festival, explore a heritage village, enjoy Goan cuisine, spend an afternoon by the sea, and experience entertainment, all within the same journey. The government's responsibility is to ensure respect for sacred spaces, appropriate zoning, noise discipline, and sensitivity toward local communities. Coexistence is one of Goa's greatest strengths. Responsible tourism allows different experiences to flourish without one diminishing the other.

There are persistent concerns about waste management, public transport, and the proliferation of unregistered properties. What is actually being done?

These are not separate tourism issues. They are the operating system of a destination. On waste, we have a dedicated agency managing cleanliness across 51 beaches, supported by a Beach Vigil mobile application where any visitor or resident can record a concern and receive a response within a defined service level. On accommodation, Goa's tourism story began with local families opening their homes and kitchens to visitors , we want to preserve that warmth while bringing homestays, villas, and guesthouses into a clear framework of registration, safety, training, and service standards. Digital registration and better inter-departmental data sharing are helping us distinguish responsible operators from illegal ones.

The decline in foreign tourist arrivals has been a talking point for some years. Is that trend reversible?

Yes - but recovery will not come by waiting for the old charter model to return unchanged. Traditional international markets remain important, but we are building a more diversified portfolio across Europe, Russia, Central Asia, the Middle East, and emerging markets. The central challenge is direct international connectivity. A state can create demand and offer incentives, but international routes are also shaped by airline economics, bilateral rights, and national aviation policy. We have therefore advocated greater destination-sensitive flexibility for tourism-driven states. This is a recalibration, not a retreat. The objective is a more resilient and geographically diverse international market mix.



CM Dr Pramod Sawant launching the "Ekadasha Teertha Yatra" in the distinguished presence of Tourism & IT Minister Rohan Khaunte, Damodar (Damu) Naik, GTDC Chairman & MLA Kedar J Naik, MLA of Priol Constituency Govind Gaude, Director of Tourism Kedar A Naik, Managing Director of GTDC Kuldeep Arolkar, and others

You hold the Information Technology portfolio alongside Tourism. How do you see AI and digital infrastructure reshaping the visitor experience?

Technology should remove friction without removing the human warmth of hospitality. A visitor should be able to move through a seamless digital journey, from discovery and booking to permits, mobility, payments, safety information, and grievance redressal. For the government, real-time data can improve licensing, crowd management, carrying-capacity decisions, waste deployment, and emergency response. AI can support multilingual assistance, accessible travel, and more personalized itineraries, but it must be built on reliable local information, privacy safeguards, and transparent governance. Goa has the scale and digital readiness to become a tourism-technology sandbox for India — where innovation improves both the visitor experience and the quality of life for residents.



What ultimately defines Goa's next chapter?

Goa's next phase must be a shift from tourism promotion to destination management. The question is no longer only how many people arrive. We must ask where they travel, how long they stay, what value remains in the local economy, what pressure is placed on infrastructure, and whether residents experience tourism as an opportunity or a burden. Goa must remain India's most iconic leisure destination while becoming a national model for tourism that creates prosperity without eroding identity. The Hon'ble Prime Minister has described Goa as a place where the spirit of Ek Bharat, Shreshtha Bharat can be experienced in every season. Our responsibility is to translate that spirit into measurable outcomes and to leave this destination better than we found it.

For Rohan Khaunte, the measure of success is neither the footfall figure nor the tourism award. It is the Goan fisherman who earns more, the village woman whose homestay is fully booked, and the visitor who leaves understanding that Goa was always more than its beaches and returns to discover the rest.